



funding fervour has almost doubled for AI firms, despite the overall drop in funding and the valuation drops across the space.

Not just start-ups, even big tech and other companies are trying to ride the AI gravy train. Microsoft, Google, Meta and others have poured billions of dollars into AI investments, starting an AI arms race of sorts. Not to be left behind, even Indian IT firms have taken a proactive stance, with TCS, Infosys, and Wipro announcing generative AI services and products in the past month.

Now, if you think this is the first time that entrepreneurs, investors, companies and advertisers are performing this buzzword ballet, let's rewind the clock to the not-so-distant past, when the buzzword du jour was undoubtedly 'crypto'. Start-ups left, right and centre were vying for a piece of the crypto pie, slinging words like tokenisation, Web3, decentralisation, blockchain, NFT, metaverse, DeFi, etc., everywhere.

Data from Crunchbase shows that from January 1, 2021, to December 31, 2021, crypto start-ups raised a staggering \$30.2 billion.

Big tech had also made big commitments to crypto. Apple, Amazon, Google, Microsoft—all of them had invested billions of dollars in the crypto, blockchain and metaverse space. Social networking giant Facebook took it a notch higher and changed its name to Meta to bolster its metaverse credentials. The digital asset revolution was just around the corner, ready to burst into our lives, and finance was going to become democratised like never before.

But 2022 rang in rising interest rates, and pushed investors to pull out money from risky assets. Then some major crypto players collapsed—Terra Luna, 3AC, Celsius, Voyager, BlockFi, FTX, etc.—pushing the space into a deeper abyss. The crypto frenzy had faded, and so did the chorus of crypto buzzwords.

Is the buzzword ballet of AI-powered firms different this time around? Are AI companies here to stay, or would they be gone with the wind too? And what will the buzzwords for the next round be? Quantum? Neuro? Or something entirely unexpected? **BT**

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# Turning Point

**With food delivery platforms nearing profitability or already achieving it, has the tide turned for the industry or will ONDC's entry into the segment make it tougher for the incumbents?**

**BY BINU PAUL**

► **THE ONLINE FOOD** delivery business, one of the most well-funded start-up verticals in India, is finally beginning to show signs of profitability. Market leaders Swiggy and Zomato have just announced profitability in their respective verticals, marking a turning point for the sector.

Swiggy's Co-founder and CEO Sriharsha Majety, in a recent blog post, claimed that after accounting for all corporate costs, excluding employee stock option costs, the company's food delivery business has turned profitable as of March 2023. "This is a milestone for food delivery globally, not just for us, as Swiggy has become one of the very few global food delivery platforms to achieve profitability in less than nine years since its inception," he wrote.

The very next day, Zomato said its business, excluding quick commerce (Blinkit), has turned 'adjusted Ebitda positive' in the March quarter. This means that the company's operating earnings, barring certain non-cash expenses and one-time charges, are greater than its operating expenses. Zomato attributes its accomplishment to